

Dale Sanders Completes Appalachian Trail at 91

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

Dale Sanders has set a hiking record at age 91. On August 31, 2026, the Memphis, Tennessee, **resident** became the oldest person to complete the entire Appalachian Trail.

The trail stretches 2,198 miles from Georgia to Maine. It crosses forests, mountains and rocky ground. According to the report, hikers must cover the whole **route** within 365 days to officially finish. They may walk **sections** in any order and take breaks between them.

Sanders, nicknamed Grey Beard, finished in 359 days. He began on September 6, 2025, at Harpers Ferry, West Virginia, near the trail's middle. He wanted to enjoy Georgia's colorful **autumn** leaves.

He took a winter break to avoid snow, then returned in spring. He averaged about 12 miles a day, with one rest day each week.

The journey was difficult. After a fall, numbness in his arm led to a hospital visit. Tests showed a pinched nerve, and he was later allowed to continue. His family and supporters **encouraged** him when he nearly stopped.

Sanders first held this record in 2017, at 82. His friend M.J. Eberhart broke it at 83 in 2021. Sanders then decided to try again.

He credits daily exercise and a positive attitude for his **endurance**, the ability to keep going through a long effort.

Word Treasure

resident -- A person who lives in a particular place.

route -- The path followed to get from place to place.

sections -- Separate parts of something larger.

autumn -- The season also called fall.

encouraged -- Gave someone support to keep trying.

endurance -- The ability to keep going through a long effort.

Background you need

The Appalachian Trail stretches from Georgia to Maine through forests, mountains and rocky ground.

The report says hikers may complete different sections in any order and take breaks within the 365-day limit.

Break it down

Introduces Sanders and his age record.

Explains the trail's length and reported completion rules.

Describes his starting point, seasonal break and walking routine.

Explains a health setback and support from others.

Ends with his earlier record and his explanation of endurance.

Why it matters

Sanders' journey gives readers an example of a long-term goal involving planning, rest and support from others.

Test what you remember

1. What record did Sanders set at age 91?
 - (A) Youngest person to guide Appalachian Trail hikers
 - (B) Fastest person to finish the Appalachian Trail
 - (C) First person to map the Appalachian Trail
 - (D) Oldest person to finish the Appalachian Trail
2. How long did Sanders take to complete the trail?
 - (A) 365 days
 - (B) 140 days
 - (C) 359 days
 - (D) 91 days
3. Where did Sanders begin his hike?
 - (A) Memphis, Tennessee
 - (B) A forest in Georgia
 - (C) A mountain in Maine
 - (D) Harpers Ferry, West Virginia
4. Why did Sanders take a winter break?
 - (A) To enjoy Georgia's autumn leaves
 - (B) To visit his friend's hometown
 - (C) To start a different trail
 - (D) To avoid hiking in snow
5. Who broke Sanders' earlier trail record in 2021?
 - (A) One of his hospital doctors
 - (B) An unnamed trail supporter
 - (C) One of his family members
 - (D) His friend M.J. Eberhart
6. What does Sanders credit for his endurance?
 - (A) Special equipment and shorter hiking routes
 - (B) Faster walking and fewer rest days
 - (C) Winter hiking and a different starting point
 - (D) Daily exercise and a positive attitude

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: D 4: D 5: D 6: D

1. Dale Sanders: Sanders credits daily exercise and a positive attitude for his endurance.